F06 — Independent Risk and Feasibility Assurance Framework

PSS Acceptance 360 | Version 1.0 | 19 October 2026 | Prepared for possible future authorised discussion

CRITICAL CONTROL: This document DESIGNS a future independent assurance review. No independent assessor has been appointed; no field testing, legal sign-off, audit, certification or investment review has occurred. It must not be presented as an independent assurance opinion or as a PSS-authorised document.

Document control and assurance boundary

Attribute	Controlled interpretation
Purpose	Challenge the integrated strategic, bank, merchant, product, technical, regulatory, commercial, financial and sourcing hypotheses before an investment or pilot decision.
Prepared by	Prospective Research, Product and Business Development division management desk research (personal pre-appointment).
Status	F06 review framework / UNPERFORMED independent assurance; 0 independent reviews; 0 cleared gates.
Source baseline	S01–S03; V02–V05; P01–P04; F02–F05. Subject to individual version review and source-to-claim reconciliation.
Independent reviewer	To be designated by future authorised PSS governance. Programme author cannot attest to independence of own work.
Permitted current activity	Public-source evidence indexing, theoretical challenge-test design and internal handover preparation only.
Out of scope now	Bank interviews; accessing bank/PSS sensitive data; regulator consultation as PSS; security testing; independent certification; vendor bids or procurement action.

Executive conclusion

The prior preparatory documents establish an internally coherent candidate service (bank-scoped evidence ingestion, reconciliation, exception handling and reusable connectivity), but they do not establish a financeable or legally deployable product. The current assurance status is INDETERMINATE / NOT READY, not a negative or positive technical, commercial or legal certification. F06 is designed to discover disconfirming evidence rather than to protect an earlier preference.

Recommendation for future appointment: ask an appropriately independent sponsor to authorise a bounded assurance work programme only after data access and governance controls. Maintain options A (full suite), B (Operate + Connect), C (PSS Pay-led), D (partner-managed) and E (no new investment) on comparable terms. No release of build capital, live bank data, a supplier award or production pilot should be inferred from this document.

1 Decision question and counterfactual

The decision is not “can a software architecture be drawn?” It is whether PSS can create a narrowly defined service that a named bank buyer will fund because its net economic value exceeds all bank costs, while PSS can provide it profitably through a verified, secure, licenced/contractually permitted and resilient operating model. Any value claim must be incremental to business-as-usual, not to an artificially weak counterfactual.

Alternative	Challenge to be answered	Stop/reversal signal
A — Full 360	Is the incremental value of Accept/Grow/Agent proven, and are their regulatory/security burdens funded?	Revenue or benefits depend on hypothetical cross-module adoption.
B — Operate + Connect	Do banks pay enough for	Bank benefit ceiling < PSS viable price

	exception/reconciliation services, with usable and lawful event feeds?	floor.
C — PSS Pay-led	Is existing announced payment product operational and certificated for exact configured deployment?	Readiness or economics stronger only in unverified publicity.
D — Partner-managed	Does partner TCO, data control and exit protection beat reuse/hybrid under like assumptions?	Hidden exit or SLA liabilities dominate contract price.
E — No investment	Can bank/PSS operations improvement or existing partners solve the identified problem better?	BAU outperforms on risk-adjusted incremental return.

2 Independence and assurance roles

Use the IIA Three Lines Model [PUB-01] as a role-separation template, not as a claim about PSS's actual organisation. Programme management owns the case and control implementation; Risk/Compliance/Legal and Finance challenge second-line matters; Internal Audit or a suitably appointed external party supplies independent assurance under the mandate and safeguards set by the governing body. An independent reviewer should not be the author, commercial sponsor, technology vendor or programme delivery lead.

Role (proposed)	Work and decision boundary
Programme / Product	Provides the theory, data, risk log and response to challenges; does not self-approve the business case.
Bank economic buyer / Bank Finance	Confirms bank baseline, value ceiling, contractual obligations and ability to pay.
PSS Technology / Operations	Provides actual architecture, performance, lifecycle cost, testing and SLA evidence.
Risk / CISO / DPO / Legal	Reviews risk appetite, privacy, licences, incident obligations and cyber evidence.
CFO / Treasury / Procurement	Assesses hurdle, tax/FX/cash, supplier options and staged capital exposure.
Independent assurance lead	Sets challenge sample, performs or commissions re-tests, records objections and qualified opinion.
Governing body / authorised committee	Owns final risk appetite and stage funding decision; cannot delegate regulatory duties by label.

3 Evidence standard and scoring protocol

For each challenge, capture the source, document owner, date, content extract, document version, evidence class, independence grade, conclusion and contradictory results. A current press statement or market statistic supports only its exact public claim; it does not support a verified PSS integration, signed bank contract, working product, merchant conversion rate or bank-specific savings.

Evidence level	Acceptance / handling
E0 — Not provided	No conclusion; hard gate remains uncleared.
E1 — Public / company-reported	Useful context; no proof of PSS internal operation or contractual permission.
E2 — Internal owner assertion	May identify next test, but lacks independent reproduction.
E3 — Document-backed primary record	Signed contracts, current controls, verified logs or approved internal records; assess authenticity/scope.
E4 — Independently reproduced	Independent test, validated bank finance workings or direct verification; review validity period.
E5 — Formally endorsed	Relevant authorised sign-off after technical/legal/financial review. Does not substitute for binding regulator permission.

Review outcomes: "Unperformed", "Evidence requested", "In review", "Supported", "Partly supported", "Contradicted", or "Not applicable with documented rationale". A hard gate is cleared only with a signed, scope-

specific decision and evidence ID; counts of "Supported" challenges are not a replacement for legal or security permission. Unresolved and contradictory findings must not be averaged into a pass.

4 Priority red-team challenge register

The accompanying workbook defines 47 individual adversarial tests across 8 domains. Each includes the exact proposition to disprove, requested evidence owner, failure indicator, linked documents and a blank reviewer disposition. The following are the highest-consequence examples.

Area	Question that could overturn the case	What independent evidence is decisive
Bank demand	Does an actual budget-holder agree the bank gains more than it pays?	Bank-finance cost/benefit reconstruction and enforceable fee terms.
System feasibility	Can authorised read-only feeds withstand delays, duplicates and reversals without inventing settlement?	Observed trace from event to source-of-truth financial record.
Security	Can a user in Bank A ever infer or access Bank B data?	Negative isolation tests, independent vulnerabilities and mitigations.
Permission	Is every proposed PSS activity and data flow actually licensed/contracted?	Current primary licence and counsel's service-by-service opinion.
PSS economics	Do fixed costs persist when there are zero banks, and does price clear lifecycle cost?	PSS cost ledger plus independent F05 calculation and stress.
Alternative	Would BAU, existing PSS Pay, EthSwitch or a partner deliver equal buyer value at lower risk?	Equivalent TCO and benefits on common counterfactual.
Sourcing	Is PSS Trading independently benchmarked and related-party governance observed?	Ownership, tender/equivalence analysis and documented recusals.

5 Critical hard gates and stage sequence

18 decision gates are drafted and NONE is cleared. The workbook gives each gate owner, required proof, stop rule, evidence reference and decision fields. These are proposed gates, not actual existing PSS policies.

Stage	Release criterion	Prohibited if not cleared
0: Governance / access	Mandate, assurance independence, purpose-controlled access	Official research contact, internal records or external requests as PSS.
1: Commercial reality	Named bank buyer, attributable baseline, bank positive net ROI	Projected bank-paid revenue classed as validated.
2: Product / technical	Actual PSS reuse, read-only source feeds, event integrity, secure tenant isolation	Live bank transaction ingestion or merchant exposure.
3: Regulatory / supplier	Licence, lawful processing, 2026 critical infrastructure applicability, scheme/PCI product scope, vendor rights	Procurement award or pilot deployment.
4: Financial / assurance	CFO downside, achievable liquidity, independently challenged alternatives and signed dissent disposition	Incremental investment capital release.
5: Formal decision	Written staged approval with cash cap, metrics and stop triggers	Any claim that the project is funded or authorised.

6 Risk assessment and non-netting controls

30 distinct risk hypotheses span demand, strategy, technology, security, legal, sourcing, commercial, finance, governance and operations. The workbook deliberately leaves likelihood, impact, control effectiveness and residual scores UNASSESSED. A pre-filled risk score would create false certainty without PSS risk appetite and existing control testing.

- Classify any unpermitted bank data access, unlicenced regulated operation, cross-bank data leakage, critical unmitigated cyber vulnerability or uncertified required payment configuration as a hard-stop candidate, regardless of average portfolio score.
- Separate privacy/cyber control risk from settlement and customer-remedy authority. PSS payment evidence cannot stand in for the sponsoring bank's ledger or scheme settlement source of truth.
- Require owners to document existing control design and operating effectiveness separately. No evidence means "unassessed", not "low likelihood".
- For each material issue capture management response, promised owner, due date, closure evidence, retest and explicit reviewer acceptance; keep unresolved dissent in the investment pack.

7 Financial model and optimism-bias independent re-performance

F05 is a 60-month unlevered nominal-ETB preparation model, not a verified investment forecast. Its cash-flow mechanics must be recomputed on an independent worksheet or separate model, not merely eyeballed. Bank ramp, attrition, fixed OPEX during zero-bank months, renewal capital, supplier costs, service credits, tax, FX and data-protection/assurance costs must be challenge inputs. NPV, IRR, payback and funding exposure are only reporting outputs after validated assumptions.

Adversarial case	Minimum reviewer check
Sponsor delay / loss	Remove earliest and largest anticipated sponsor, compare cash trough and payback.
Bank price ceiling	Replace chosen tariff with actual buyer ceiling; test floor-ceiling overlap.
Build/operating overrun	Add vendor repricing, cyber/DR, manual disputes and bank integration slippage.
Zero-bank months	Hold fixed operating and certification costs throughout the non-revenue period.
No unapproved revenues	Delete assumed scheme interchange, subsidies, MDR, merchant float and unsigned opportunities.
Alternative sensitivity	Apply same tax, nominal ETB hurdle and lifecycle horizon to A/B/C/D/E.
Risk/reliability	Simulate outage, reversal backlog and contract service credits.
FX / tax / liquidity	Reconcile payable currencies, tax and funding available before any capital release.

8 Regulatory, cybersecurity and source-control exceptions

INSA documents published in 2026 include Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity Proclamation No. 1426/2026 and a designated-sector standard [PUB-04, PUB-05]. Finance is a listed sector, but that public statement does not verify whether PSS or a proposed Acceptance 360 service is designated. Current applicability, required notification, approval and timing need PSS counsel and competent-authority review.

NIST CSF 2.0 [PUB-02] is used to structure risk-governance and security test evidence, not to confer certification. PCI DSS, MPoC scheme/product listing, EMV/QR specifications and acquirer permissions are separate scope questions. No public promotional statement should be treated as an active listing or authority for a new configuration.

9 Assurance work programme and review deliverables

Future phase	Work product	Required independent decision
1 — Commission	Review charter, scope, auditor competence/independence and access restrictions	Independence accepted and records controlled.
2 — Source reconciliation	Source-to-claim matrix and contradictory-source register	No unsupported claim moves into investment memorandum.
3 — Evidence walkthrough	Bank buyers, actual PSS systems, legal perimeter, economic model and procurement	Sample-size/sufficiency documented; gaps escalated.

4 — Reperformance	Technical negative tests, bank-side savings, F05 60-month model and supplier comparison	Independent exceptions/retests retained.
5 — Challenge meeting	Management responses, unresolved dissent and final risk prioritisation	No board decision while hard-stop unresolved.
6 — Report / recommendation	Signed opinion with limitations and recommendation on A/B/C/D/E	Approve research / conditional pilot / defer / partner / stop only within real authority.

10 Future assurance opinion: possible conclusion taxonomy

Conclusion label	Definition
Not assessed	Insufficient access/evidence; exactly the current F06 state.
Feasible with documented restrictions	Applicable gates independently met; manageable limitations and staged release conditions.
Conditionally feasible	Important non-blocking issues remain; no live/capital step until conditions verified.
Infeasible in current form	Demonstrated material technical, regulatory, bank-value or financial contradiction.
Decline / cease	Unacceptable legal/security exposure or negative economic case; prefer BAU or alternate option.
Cannot express opinion	Evidence denied, quality insufficient or independence compromised.

11 Management action before and after joining

Before appointment, only organise these public and previously authored research templates, maintain the personal action notebook, and track new public regulatory evidence. Do not solicit banks or suppliers on PSS letterhead, claim a review panel has been constituted, send a formal RFI or request PSS/internal data without authority.

After appointment, proposed sequence: obtain CEO/Legal mandate; commission appropriately independent reviewers through proper governance; open an access-controlled evidence register; invite bank financial buyers by permission; verify technical and legal gates; perform independent model re-computation; record dissent; seek appropriately scoped management decision. F01 integrated feasibility must faithfully carry F06 objections rather than smooth them into a positive average.

Sources, evidence status and limitations

[PUB-01] The Institute of Internal Auditors. The IIA Three Lines Model (2020; official statement). https://www.theiia.org/en/content/communications/2020/july/20-july-2020-iia-issues-important-update-to-three-lines-model/ — Use limit: Assurance role separation only.

[PUB-02] NIST. Cybersecurity Framework 2.0 (2024). https://www.nist.gov/publications/nist-cybersecurity-framework-csf-20 — Use limit: Cyber governance outcome framework, not certification.

[PUB-03] World Bank PPP Reference. Assessing project feasibility and economic viability. https://ppp.worldbank.org/assessing-project-feasibility-and-economic-viability — Use limit: Methodological lens on options, bias and risk.

[PUB-04] INSA Ethiopia. Official documentations (2026 critical infrastructure rule and standard). https://www.insa.gov.et/documentations — Use limit: Sector-level public evidence; PSS application unverified.

[PUB-05] INSA Ethiopia. INSA public statement on proclamation No. 1426/2026, 7 Aug 2026. https://www.insa.gov.et/blog/Critical-Infrastructure-Cybersecurity-Proclamation-Marks-a-Major-Step-Toward-Safeguarding-Ethiopia%27s-Digital-Sovereignty-%E2%80%93-INSA-Director-General-Tigist-Hamid — Use limit: Finance listed; PSS designation unverified.

Internal programme baseline: S01–S03, V02–V05, P01–P04 and F02–F05 prepared as personal pre-appointment drafts in this project. They have not been independently validated by PSS; dates/versions shown are for document identification rather than institutional adoption.

Blank future institutional sign-off

Future institutional role	Reviewer / date / evidence / disposition
Independent assurance lead	[not appointed]
Risk and Compliance	[not reviewed]
Legal and Data Protection	[not reviewed]
Chief Information Security Officer	[not reviewed]
Chief Financial Officer	[not reviewed]
Executive / Board sponsor	[not approved]